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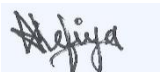
Department of English Literature, National University of Singapore

EN2202 Critical Reading

Dr. Susan Ang

30th March 2021

I declare that all material in this assignment is my own work and does not involve plagiarism. Furthermore, I have not used any secondary material in my analysis.

Signature:  Date: 30th March 2021

In writing the following essay, I have set out to:

1. Construct a clear and concise thesis statement
2. Organize an essay by ideas
3. Begin paragraphs with appropriate signposting and clear topic sentences

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The Shackle of Expression:

Irony in Atwood's *Marrying the Hangman*

'Marrying the Hangman' traces the narrator as she chronicles the story of a female prisoner who, under patriarchal laws, could escape a death sentence by marrying the hangman. Though the prose poem uses short, unadorned sentences organized in uneven stanzas, this simplicity is juxtaposed by sudden shifts in perspective, suggestive motifs, lurking paradoxes, and open-ended questions that force the reader to examine whether the given nature of the circumstances that both the prisoner and the narrator's friends are facing is as transparent as it seems. This essay argues that through the presentation and subsequent subversion of apparently exclusive binaries, Atwood posits that expression is a means of confinement for women.

The premise of 'Marrying the Hangman' primes the reader to the idea of captivity. The poem explains that according to the law, an incarcerated man can be freed if he takes on the duties of a hangman, while an incarcerated woman can be released if she marries the hangman. The repetition of the word "escape" creates a salience that demands the attention of the reader and evokes a double meaning: the need for escape necessitates an imprisonment, while the desire to escape denotes the contrary desire for freedom. The visual layout of the poem, in rectangular boxes of text, symbolises this constraint – it signifies both a literal restriction of the jail, and the metaphorical limitation of a text itself, which we will return to shortly.

However, the proposed freedom / imprisonment binary is rife with insinuated contradiction. The female prisoner, who is experiencing a loss of identity in her captivity, is described as "living selflessly" – a phrase that overturns the instinctive association of altruism to selflessness, contextually making it into a disintegration of identity. The male prisoner gives up his chance at freedom to become the hangman, because it is ironically "his only chance to be a hero." This contradiction of freedom is most readily highlighted in the sentence "there is no hangman; thus there is no escape." To ordinary prisoners, the absence of a hangman grants them a longer life. On the other hand, in the case of the female prisoner, the hangman's absence constitutes a lack of means to escape prison.

Atwood first associates expression with imprisonment through the prisoner's story. The prisoner can be free from her death sentence only when she persuades the man to take on the "impersonal mask of death." By using her voice, which is the only part of her body that has not been restricted by the prison, she convinces the man to become the hangman and take her as his wife. However, this means of escape through marriage is merely another form of imprisonment – realised when the narrator rhetorically asks how the female prisoner felt when "she discovered she had left one locked room for another?" Ironically, her freedom of expression, which saved her from death, ultimately subjected her to a life of restriction and suffering. Thus, the initially mutually exclusive categories of 'freedom' and 'imprisonment' are subverted in the story of the prisoner.

Atwood signals the theme of contradiction most explicitly through her categorization of fantasy and history. The sentence, "This is not fantasy, it is history," is interspersed across the poem, most notably punctuating the end of the first stanza. The statement lays out 'fantasy' and 'history' as opposing concepts that are mutually exclusive. This assertion has a ubiquitous logic – history as a discipline is taken to be empirically sourced, whereas fantasy is fictitious and therefore not an immutable truth. However, set in the text, this logic

contradicts itself: the work is a piece of fictional writing classifying itself as historical. The paradoxical existence of this historical fiction results in a dissolution of boundaries within the history / fantasy binary.

The conflation of 'history' and 'fantasy' is heightened through the use of linguistic devices. The origin of the words themselves imply a correspondence taking place between the concepts. A story, defined as a real or imaginative account, and history, the narrative of the past, both derive from the Latin *historia* – etymologically denoting an interconnectedness between fantasy and history. Indeed, the word history can be split into hi/story. On the other hand, the word fantasy is derived from the Greek *phantazein*, meaning to make visible – which is, arguably, related to the purpose of history itself in making the past visible.

It can be argued that Atwood uses the word 'fantasy' deliberately to point to this complex reciprocity: a synonym such as 'fiction' (derived from Latin *fingere*, meaning to contrive) would have bestowed a more direct contradiction to 'history' through its etymological meaning of feigning and falsehood. 'History' and 'fantasy' are also aurally similar half-rhymes, identical in number of syllables and meter. The repetition across stanzas and close pairing of both the words with each other provides a lyrical quality to the prose poem and further conflates the binary.

This blurring of the lines between fantasy and history takes shape in the text as Atwood breaks away from the story of the hangman's bride to describe a discussion among her friends about the abuse they have faced. The sudden shift to first-person narrative creates a sense of realism: it is easier for the reader to accept the simple act of talking to friends as truth rather than the outlandish concept of escaping a death sentence by marrying a hangman. It indicates that current narration is separate from the prisoner's story, but this supposition is undermined by the categorization of this event, too, as history.

She bridges the divide between these two narratives to further. The woman's act of expression through story telling also performs the function of bridging by alluding to the freedom / imprisonment binary. Just as the prisoner used her voice to create the hangman who would end up imprisoning her, the women use their voices to share their stories, which ultimately weigh them down. By explicitly assigning the role of the hangman to her friend's abuser as she says, "there is more than one hangman," she superimposes the prisoner's circumstances onto that of her friend's.

The merging of the narratives exacerbates the simultaneous merging of history and fantasy, magnified by the liminality of time in the story. The use of present tense in both the story of the prisoner and the narration of the women at the table prompts the reader to contemplate the now-omnipresent difficult nature of the two situations – and ask whether there exists any difference between the terrible choice the prisoner faces, and the story the narrator's friend relays. Though the text designates both these events as history, neither one is occurring in the past, leading to a blending of (what seems to be) the fictional past and the present reality.

This subversion of the history and fantasy binary paints the ironic oppression conducted by feminine self-expression. Atwood first signals this irony in the initial first-person stanza, saying, "we tell stories . . . so we can finally believe." A paradox is created – instead of relying on past (and therefore historical) experiences to construct their anecdotes, the women can only consider their experiences as believable and true through treating them as fantastical stories. Hence, their freedom of expression binds them into facing the awful things they have been subjected to.

This paradox of expression in the prisoner's story extends and applies itself to the whole poem in the latter first-person stanza. Through the sentence "the fact is there are no

stories I can tell my friends," the reader realizes that Atwood's story of the prisoner is, in fact, her contribution to the discussion with her friends. Notably, this is the rare instance in the poem where a phrase in concretized, as indicated by the word "fact" – the one immutable truth in the poem is that no expression can alleviate the women's pain.

The identification of this metacommentary also allows the reader to revisit the implications of the visual layout of the text – the individually unjustified lines suggest a freedom in the expressive act of writing, but the collective shape of the stanzas as boxes on the page reinforce the idea of restraint that pervades the text. This metacommentary is compounded when she goes on to say that though this story will not make them feel better, they "can soothe [themselves] by speculating about [history]." Though the story is meant to reassure the women, the very inability to tell history from fiction that the narrator has woven leads them to become horrified at the story.

Atwood, in expressing the fantastical tale of the hangman's wife and linking it to the horrific incidents that her friends have gone through, lends plausibility to her own speculations about the historical tale of prisoner. However, the now-plausible speculations, which are meant to "soothe" them, ironically only serve to make the women and the reader confront the enduring oppression of the female voice.

Goals

I believe that I have successfully attempted to meet my goals of using topic sentences and structuring an essay by idea and content rather than merely tracing the text as it proceeds. Though I have defined a thesis statement, I am not satisfied with it – in my opinion, it required more depth and detail; however, I was unsure of how to negotiate that level of detail with the need to be concise.

Essay Feedback form

Section: Date:

Content	Grade	Helpful Feedback
***Topic** • is clearly stated • is well chosen • is well scoped		
***Thesis Statement** • Clearly identifiable/well flagged up • Present • Clear • Interesting • Has potential • Adequately complex		
Topic Sentences • Clearly identifiable • Present at start of paragraph • Related to paragraph, summarizing it • Related to thesis explicitly		
Detail • Has a high level of detail • Detail is useful/relevant		

****Critical Thinking: Evidence** • Evidence used to support claims • Awareness of types & limitations of evidence		
****Critical Thinking: Reasoning & Analysis** • Reasoning process is clear and logical • Good judgment in selection of material to analyse • Analysis is sound • Analysis is detailed • Analysis is relevant to the thesis • Analysis is original		
Style and Language • **Grammar** • **Style** • **Syntax** • **Vocabulary** • **No verbal tics** • **Expression is clear** • **Expression is elegant and articulate**		

Argument • **Is trackable** • **Follows logically** • **Develops** • **Is sound** • **Is original**		
Formatting and Presentation • **Has a cover sheet** • **Follows stylesheet** • **Is consistent** • **Is tidy** • **References conscientiously** • **Has page numbers** • **Has signed statement**		
Secondary Reading • **Present** • **Functional** • **Engaged with** • **Well-chosen** • **Current**		

Shows improvement from last assignment (if appropriate) • **Carefulness** • **In choice of words** • **In sharpness of ideas** • **In organization of material** • **In arriving at argument** • **In keeping argument going** • **In developing argument** • **In level of detail** • **In style** • **In grammar**		
Goals • **Are present** • **Are clear** • **Are significant** • **Are sensible** • **Are well-defined and envisaged**		
Questions (if relevant) • **Are thoughtfully shaped** • **Have potential for development** • **Show originality** • **(of other classmates) were usefully, respectfully and helpfully critiqued**		

Checklist for Student • **Are your paragraphs indented** • **Are your paragraphs neither under/over length** • **Have you included the bibliography** • **Put page numbers** • **Footnotes and main text in same font** • **Made sure you have used 'whereby', 'as such' correctly?** • **Avoided 'leverage', 'silo', 'impactful', 'impact (v)', 'recount (n)'?** • **Do you have consistent pronouns, e.g. one… one's, 'the individual…. He/she NOT theirs'** •		

Grade	*A+/A*	*A-*	*B+*	*B*	*B-*	*C+/C*
Argument	*Complex, sound, develops, coherent, has potential for further development, is original, clear, trackable and signposted. Good follow through A+ this*	*Moderately complex, sound, some development, coherent, clear, trackable and signposted, good follow through*	*Sound, clear, coherent, trackable, some development, fairly standard but competently put together, some follow through*	*Sound, clear, but formulation of terms either undeveloped or crude, fairly standard, some follow through*	*Thin, weak but not altogether unsound, undeveloped, static, terms of reference crude, limited follow through*	*Thin, weak, or lacking, incoherent, unclear, no follow through*

	plus sparkle					
Analysis	*Sharp, rationalized, original and with value-add. Detailed. Sophisticated. Clear. Efficient. Well-articulated. Connected to argument. Good literary judgment*	*Sharp, rationalized, efficient, some originality and value-add. Quite detailed. Well-articulated. Clear. Moderately sophisticated. Connected to argument. Good literary judgment*	*Sound, clear, sensible, moderately detailed, some value add. Connected to argument. Good literary judgment*	*Sound, clear, plausible, some detail. Tries to connect to argument*	*Occasional points which are moderately sensible and evidenced. Generally lacking in detail and follow through Intermittant awareness of argument*	*Thin, weak, shows poor judgement, unsustained, lacks detail. Points unconnected and random. Unlinked to argument.*
Style	*Elegant, crisp, good English, clear, sophisticated, good vocabulary and appropriate use of critical terms*	*Elegant, crisp, good English, clear, good vocabulary and appropriate use of critical terms*	*Efficient, clear, good English, moderately good vocabulary and appropriate use of critical terms*	*Efficient, clear, moderately good English, competent vocabulary and awareness of critical terms*	*Clear, moderately good English, some awareness of critical vocabulary*	*Consistent grammatical and syntactical errors, verbal tics, wrong use of words or critical terms.*
Detail	*Level of detail very high, detail relevant and useful, eye for unusual detail*	*Level of detail high, detail relevant and useful*	*Level of detail moderate, detail relevant and useful*	*Level of detail on low side, detail mostly relevant and useful*	*Low level of detail, not always relevant or useful*	*Low level of detail; detail irrelevant*
Write-up	*Knows how to paragraph, how to optimize placement of points and*	*Knows how to paragraph, how to optimize placement of points and*	*Knows how to paragraph, how to optimize placement of points and*	*Knows how to paragraph. Uses appropriate connectors*	*Paragraphing and arrangement of material somewhat arbitrary. Uses some*	*Paragraphing and arrangement of material arbitrary, and incoherent.*

	elaboration, knows how to shift between levels of textual discussion, argument and meta-argument. Uses appropriate connectors and rhetorical moves are persuasive and intelligent	*elaboration, able to shift between textual discussion and argument. Uses appropriate connectors and rhetorical moves are persuasive and intelligent*	*elaboration. Uses appropriate connectors and has some sense of rhetorical moves*		*connectors but with a large sprinkling of the faux-connectors*	*No sense of connectors.*

Additional feedback: